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International Conference

Theme:Democracy andDevelopment in Africa Within the Context of Global Democratic Reversal

Date

26th - 29th August 2026

Venue

Aston University, Birmingham, United Kingdom



WELCOME NOTE

Distinguished keynote speakers, esteemed professors, respected scholars, researchers, policymakers, students, ladies and gentlemen, good morning and welcome. It is both a privilege and a genuine pleasure to welcome you to this international conference titled Democracy and Development in Africa within the Context of Global Democratic Reversal. We are delighted that despite busy schedules, long flights, cancelled meetings, and perhaps one or two battles with airport security over an overstuffed suitcase full of books, you are here with us today. For that, we sincerely thank you. Someone once joked that if you place ten academics in one room, you will hear fifteen opinions before lunch. Looking around this hall, I suspect we may produce at least fifty before tea break, and that is exactly how it should be. Democracy, after all, is not built on everyone thinking alike; it flourishes because people have the freedom to disagree respectfully while searching together for better answers.

Our conference theme is timely. Around the world, democratic institutions are under pressure. Trust in public institutions is declining, elections are contested, misinformation spreads faster than facts, and more people are asking difficult questions about governance and accountability. Africa is not isolated from these realities even as we are resilient, innovative, energetic, and determined to build stronger and more inclusive societies. Over the next sessions, we shall hear fascinating discussions on elections, digital democracy, women's participation, media freedom, local governance, youth engagement, Pan-Africanism, Ubuntu, democratic resistance, social justice, land reform, entrepreneurship, technology, and many other issues that remind us that democracy is not merely about voting every few years. It is about dignity, participation, accountability, opportunity, and the everyday experiences of ordinary people. No single discipline, country, institution, or generation possesses all the answers. Historians need political scientists, economists need lawyers, sociologists need data scientists, and policymakers need researchers. Researchers certainly need practitioners to remind us that real life rarely behaves like our theoretical models.

This conference therefore offers more than an opportunity to present papers. It offers an opportunity to listen carefully, to challenge assumptions respectfully, to build friendships across borders, and perhaps to begin collaborations that will outlive this event. I encourage every participant not simply to present their papers but to engage in meaningful conversations, ask questions, exchange contacts, visit posters, and challenge ideas without attacking people. Some of the most valuable outcomes of conferences do not happen during formal presentations but during coffee breaks, lunch conversations, or while waiting for the next session to begin.

As we officially begin this conference, let us remember that democracy is not a destination that a nation reaches once and forever. It is an ongoing conversation, requiring courage, participation, patience, and constant renewal. Development, likewise, is not measured only by economic statistics but by whether citizens experience justice, inclusion, security, opportunity, and hope. Thank you for honouring this gathering with your presence. May our discussions be rigorous, our debates respectful, our learning enriching, and our shared commitment to Africa's democratic future even stronger when we leave than when we arrived.

Once again, welcome, and I wish every one of us a productive and memorable conference. Thank you

CONFERENCE OVERVIEW

The International Conference on Democracy and Development in Africa Within the Context of Global Democratic Reversal provides a multidisciplinary platform for scholars, researchers, policymakers and practitioners to critically examine the changing state of democracy and its implications for Africa's development. Hosted at Aston University in Birmingham, United Kingdom, the conference promotes meaningful dialogue on how African societies can strengthen democratic institutions, enhance accountable governance, and advance inclusive and sustainable development amid the global decline of democratic values and practices.

Beyond examining the causes and consequences of democratic reversal, the conference seeks to generate evidence-based recommendations, innovative governance approaches and contextually relevant African solutions.
By bringing together diverse perspectives and experiences, it aims to strengthen collaboration, contribute to scholarly and policy debates, and identify practical pathways towards democratic resilience, social inclusion, institutional accountability and sustainable development across Africa.



PROF. KAYODE EESUOLA

HEAD OF RESEARCH

Institute of African & Diaspora Studies,
University of Lagos, Nigeria

Kayode Eesuola is an African Studies-based Research Professor of Political Science. An alumnus of the Institute of American Politics and Political Thoughts, and The Study of United States Institutes, Eesuola has been awarded many competitive research fellowships and grants that have been published in many academic outlets. The latest of his research is funded by the German Research Foundation, with the scope of identifying the social and political thoughts in the Yoruba knowledge systems. Eesuola currently heads the Governance and Financial Integrity Unit at the Institute of African and Diaspora Studies, University of Lagos. He is also an Extraordinary Professor for the North West University, South Africa.

KEYNOTE SPEAKERS



PROF. PHEMELO OLIFILE MARUMO

DEPUTY DIRECTOR

School of Philosophy, Northwest University Mahikeng Campus

Prof. Phemelo Olifile Marumo currently works at the School of Philosophy, Faculty of Humanities, Northwest University. His interests are Missiology and African studies based on African Philosophy. Prof Marumo's research focus area is African Philosophy and Comparative Religion. He has contributed to various Journals whereby he was blending African Philosophy and Missiology stance in a Postmodern era. He has written much on African philosophy.



PROF. TSOALEDI DANIEL THOBEJANE

HEAD

Unit for gender studies, the faculty of humanities, social sciences and education, University of Venda. South Africa.

Tsoaledi Daniel Thobejane is a professor at the University of Venda, South Africa. He holds a doctoral degree in international Education from the University of Massachusetts(USA). He obtained his Master of Science degree in Community Economic Development(Cum Laude) at the Southern New Hampshire State University (USA) in 1998. He was actively involved in the Liberation Struggle in South Africa and was subsequently arrested under the state of emergency from 1985 until 1988.Prof.Thobejane worked as the Director for the School for International Training, which was based in Brattleboro (USA), and was later deployed to South Africa, Durban,where this institution had a satellite campus. He also worked as a qualified Teacher at Somavunga High School, based in Limpopo Province. Thus far, he has published close to 60 articles and four books in the area of Politics, Gender and Education. He has also delivered keynote addresses and organized conferences at the University of Venda and abroad. His articles have received more than 800 citations internationally. He presently serves as the external examiner for many Universities while also serving as a peer reviewer for many international journals. Prof Thobejane's niche area focuses on the causes and effects of gender based violence and Intimate Partner Violence particularly in South Africa.

SESSION CHAIRS

DR. AKINWALE GBENUSHOLA ABIKE

Department of Psychology at the University of Lagos (UNILAG), Nigeria

PROF. NOFIU, OLUWASESAN AKANNI

Department of PublicAdministration,Facultyof Management and Social Sciences, Achievers university, Owo. Nigeria

DR. ISHMAEL OBAEKO IWARA

International Relations, North West University, South Africa

DR. OLUKAYODE IDRIS LASISI

Department ofAuditing,
University of South Africa

PROGRAMME

Day One-August 26th, 2026

Arrival & Registration 9am-4pm

Day Two - August 27th 2026

Welcome Address 9am-9:15am

- PROF KAYODE EESUOLA, Head of Research, Institute of African & Diaspora Studies, University of Lagos, Nigeria

Keynote Lecture 9:15am-9:45am

- Prof. Phemelo Olifile Marumo
  Deputy Director (School of Philosophy) Mahikeng Campus

TEA BREAK **9:45am-10:05am**

Session I

10:05am-10:15am

Session Chair: Dr Ishmael Obaeko Iwara

Machanduke Lucas Shipalana, Northwest University 10:15am-10:30am

- DEMOCRATIC GOVERNANCE FOR SOCIAL JUSTICE IN AFRICAN COUNTRIES. A CASE OF SOUTH AFRICA.

Prof. Hebert Sihle Ntuli, University of Zululand 10:30am-10:45am

- EXPLORING CHALLENGES FACING EDUCATION IN MODELING DEMOCRATIC CITIZENSHIP AND GOOD GOVERNANCE IN AFRICA WITHIN THE CONTEXT OF GLOBAL DEMOCRATIC REVERSAL

Mukwevho M.H; University of Venda

10:45am-11:00am

- SUFFERING IN SILENCE: A CASE OF GENDER-BASED VIOLENCE AGAINST MEN'S WELL-BEING AT KWAAI-DRAAI VILLAGE, LIMPOPO PROVINCE (SOUTH AFRICA)

Dr. Mariagoretti Ijeoma Obiakor, Dr. Nkechi Juliana Odoh, & Mrs. Amaka Patience Ogbuanya: Nnamdi Azikiwe University,Nigeria

11:00am-11:15am

- DEMOCRACY, CITIZEN EDUCATION, AND LEADERSHIP CAPACITY IN AFRICA AND ITS INFLUENCE ON NIGERIAN UNIVERSITIES

Dr. Busani Maseko - Rhodes University
School of Languages and Literatures
Eastern Cape, South Africa

11:15am-11:30pm

- COLONIALITY, ASPIRATION AND FAMILY LANGUAGE POLICY: UNDERSTANDING PARENTS AND CAREGIVERS' COMPLEX DISPOSITIONS TOWARDS CHILDREN'S TRANSLANGUAGING

Rofem Inyang Bassey, Pfarelo Matshidze, and Ishmael Obaeko Iwara; University of Venda.

11:30am-11:45am

- AFROCENTRIC CITIZENSHIP EDUCATION AS A RESOURCE FOR ETHICAL GOVERNANCE: A PERSPECTIVE FROM SOUTH AFRICA

Costa Hofisi and Kazeem Oyedele Lamidi; North West University

11:45am-12:00pm

- RESOURCE COMPETITION AND POLITICAL ECOLOGY OF FARMER– HERDER CONFLICT IN NIGERIA: IMPLICATIONS FOR SUSTAINABLE PEACE

Oluwasesan Akanni NOFIU (PhD) & Olatunji Agboola OLATEJU; Achievers University

12:00pm-12:15pm

- NON-FORMAL POLITICAL EDUCATION: A STRATEGY FOR REVERSING POLITICAL APATHY AND IRRATIONAL VOTING BEHAVIOUR IN NIGERIA

Dr. Nthabeleng Malope, Thabo Mbeki African School of Public and Internattional Affairs (UNISA) — 12:15pm-12:30pm

- RECRUITMENT, GOVERNANCE, AND THE DEMOCRATISATION OF PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION: EVIDENCE FROM COMMUNITY HEALTH WORKER PROGRAMME IN SOUTH AFRICA

Akinwale,Gbenusola and Ojakorotu,Victor Schoolof GovernmentNorth WestUniversity, Mafikeng, South Africa — 12:30-12:45pm

- Digital Media Exposure and Democratic BackslidingAmong YoungWomen in Lagos, Nigeria: The Mediating Rolesof Political Trust and Political Apathy

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Linda Paul & Prof Dr Ravinder Rena; Cape Peninsula University of Technology, District Six Campus, Cape Town, Republic of South Africa — 12:45pm-1:00pm

- ENTREPRENEURIAL GOVERNANCE: RETOOLING LOCAL ADMINISTRATION FOR SUSTAINABLE ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT IN AFRICA

Session II

1:00pm-1:10pm

Session Chair: AKINWALE Gbenushola

LUNCH — **1:10pm-2:00pm**

Sunday Michael Oguntade and Ishmael Obaeko Iwara; Damelin College, Menlyn & University of Venda — 2:00pm-2:15pm

- PEOPLE-CENTRED GOVERNANCE: A RESOURCE FOR CURBING IMPERSONATION AND UNETHICAL CONDUCT IN JOHANNESBURG'S REAL ESTATE SECTOR

Keabetswe Charmyne Modise — 2:15pm-2:30pm

- DEMOCRATISING ADMINISTRATIVE PRACTICES FOR SUSTAINABLE LOCAL ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT: EVIDENCE FROM TWO MUNICIPALITIES IN SOUTH AFRICA

Kazeem Oyedele Lamidi & Costa Hofisi
North West University, South Africa — 2:30pm-2:45pm

- Youth and Governance: Rethinking Citizen-Government Relations in Africa after Trump's Re-election

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James Muiga, United States International University — 2:45pm-3:00pm

- LEGITIMACY OF POWER: NIGER'S DEMOCRACY BACKSLIDE AND THE MESSIANIC MILITARY JUNTA.

NOFIU, Oluwasesan Akanni (Ph.D); Achievers University — 3:00pm-3:15pm

- INSECURITY AND POVERTY: TWIN CHALLENGES TO ELECTION ADMINISTRATION IN NIGERIA'S FOURTH REPUBLIC

Linda Paul and Prof Dr Ravinder Rena; Cape Peninsula University of Technology — 3:15pm-3:30pm

- The PoliticalEconomyof Entrepreneurship: Strengthening DemocraticResiliencethrough Inclusive Economic Agency

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Lusanda Paul and Prof Dr Ravinder Rena; Cape Peninsula University of Technology — 3:30pm-3:45pm

- FRAMES OF RESISTANCE: AFRICAN CINEMA AS A BULWARK AGAINST AUTOCRATIC CREEP AND MARKET MONOPOLY

Onosolease David OKOIRHON, Oluwatobi Tomi FASHIPE, and Samson JOSHUA
Dizengoff Betking Nigeria PLES IT Services

3:45pm-4:00pm

- DIGITALIZING ELECTIONS: PRIVATE SECTOR, TECHNOLOGY AND DEMOCRACY IN WEST AFRICA

Prof. A. O. Hassan; Obafemi Awolowo University.

4:00pm-4:15pm

- TECHNOLOGY AND ELECTORAL INTEGRITY IN NIGERIA: INTERROGATING THE NEXUS WITH GOOD GOVERNANCE

Dr N.P.Mahwasane;UniversityofVenda

4:15pm-4:30pm

- THEORETICAL UNDERPINNINGS OF THE DECLINE OF DEMOCRACY IN AFRICA: LIBRARY CONSIDERATION

Dr. Rich Mashimbye; University of South Africa.

4:30pm-4:45pm

- REALISM, DEMOCRACY, SOVEREIGNTY AND SECURITY IN AFRICA

Ibrahim Balqis O. & Constance Tanuoma, Glotan
Research Services Limited

4:45pm-5:00pm

- THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN DEMOCRATIC INSTITUTIONS AND ECONOMIC GROWTH IN AFRICA

Day Three - August 28th 2026

Keynote Lecture

9:00am-9:35am

- Prof. Tsoaledi Daniel Thobejane

TEA BREAK

9:35am-9:45am

Session I

9:45am-10:00am

Session Chair: Prof. Oluwasesan Akanni NOFIU

Lebogang T Legodi; University of Limpopo

10:00am-10:10am

- Beyond AGOA: Assessing China's role as a possible substitute for African Beneficiaries

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Kazeem Oyedele Lamidi and Costa Hofisi;

10:10am-10:25am

North West University

- Resource Competition and Political Ecology of Farmer–Herder Conflict inNigeria: Implications for Sustainable Peace

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Lusanda Paul & Prof Dr Ravinder Rena; Cape Peninsula University of Technology, District Six Campus, Cape Town, Republic of South Africa

10:25am-10:40am

- The Digital Frontline: Media Pluralism and Development in the Age of "Infodemics"and Media Capture

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Masego Mokgoko and Lesego Masisi; Northwest University, Faculty of Law

10:40am-10:55am

- ARCHITECTURE OF DISPOSSESSION: STRUCTURALISM, LEGAL POSITIVISM, NATIVES LAND ACT 1913 AND THE POLITICAL ECONOMY OF DEMOCRATIC TRANSFORMATION IN SOUTH AFRICA

OLOMITUTU, Adeniyi Kehinde (PhD) and OJAKOROTU, Victor (PhD): North West University 10:55am-11:05am

- DEMOCRATIC GOVERNANCE AND CIVIC EDUCATION IN NIGERIA: PATHWAYS TO SUSTAINABLE DEMOCRACY

Temitope Olayode Okeyode and Gabriel Andrew ADOLE Banks & Clarks Nig Ltd, Andre Energy Ltd 11:05am-11:20am

- NATURAL RESOURCES, OIL POLITICS AND DEMOCRACY IN NIGERIA

Olukayode Idris Lasisi; University of South Africa. 11:20am-11:35am

- BEYOND FLAG INDEPENDENCE: PAN-AFRICANISM, POLITICAL ECONOMY AND DEMOCRATIC SOVEREIGNTY IN AFRICA

Grace Olubunmi BABALOLA, Ph.D, FCAI, FCIPM, FIPMLD Deputy Registrar (Academic), Adekunle Ajasin University, Akungba-Akoko,Ondo State, Nigeria 11:35am-11:50am

- PROTECT OR PERISH: NAMING AND SHAMING, HUMAN RIGHTS DIPLOMACY, AND THE GLOBAL BARGAINING POLITICS OF NIGERIA AS 'COUNTRY OF CONCERN' DESIGNATION

Priccilar Vengesai and Masego Mokgoko University of South Africa Northwest University 11:50am-12:05pm

- ADVANCING GENDER EQUALITY IN ZIMBABWEAN DEMOCRACY: ELECTORAL DESIGN OR A POLITICAL PARTY MANDATE? LESSONS FROM SOUTH AFRICA

Samuel Chukwudi AGUNYAI, North West University 12:05pm-12:20pm

- ADDRESSING INCESSANT DEFECTION AND WEAK POLITICAL OPPOSITION FOR DEMOCRATIC CONSOLIDATION IN AFRICA: INSIGHTS FROM NIGERIA

Tumba TusekuDieudonné;Universityof South Africa 12:20pm-12:35pm

- INVESTIGATING THE DRIVERS OF ELECTORAL CORRUPTION IN AFRICAN HYBRID REGIMES: EVIDENCE FROM THE EAST AFRICAN COMMUNITY

Session II

12:35pm-12:45pm

Session Chair: Dr. Olukayode Idris Lasisi

Farisani Thomas Nephawe and Thizwilondi Josephine Mudau; University of Venda

12:45pm-1:00pm

- EXPLORING DEMOCRACY AND DEVELOPMENT: THE CONNECTION BETWEEN ENGLISH LANGUAGE AND WOMEN'S EMPOWERMENT IN AFRICA

LUNCH

1:00pm-2:00pm

Temitope Omotayo Solomon, Shedrach Ichukwu, Victor Ojakorotu; University of Ibadan and Northwest University

2:00pm-2:15pm

- DEMOCRACY AND THE POLITICS OF PROTEST (DE)LEGITIMISATION IN NIGERIA

Temitope J. Owolabi; University of Lagos

2:15pm-2:30pm

- WORK, DEMOCRACY, AND SOCIAL INCLUSION IN AFRICA: MAINSTREAMING WOMEN'S PARTICIPATION FOR DEMOCRATIC RENEWAL AND DEVELOPMENT

Ifeanyi-obi, C.C. and Wagor, P.C; University of Port Harcourt

2:30pm-2:45pm

- PERCEPTION OF GENDER RESPONSIVENESS OF THE NIGERIAN NATIONAL AGRICULTURAL EXTENSION POLICY BY AGRICULTURE PROFESSIONALS IN RIVERS STATE

Matsepe David[1], Maluleke Mugwena, Zwane Thembinkosi Trevor; South African Democratic Teachers Union Research Department, University of Johannesburg

2:45pm-3:00pm

- NEGOTIATING EQUITY AND PEACE THROUGH "POWER": THE IMPACTFUL ROLE OF TEACHER UNIONS BETWEEN THE ERA OF STRUGGLE AND RECONCILIATION IN UNJUST SCHOOL SYSTEMS

John Daniel; University of Ibadan

3:00pm-3:15pm

- DIASPORA, DIGITAL AGE, AND DEMOCRACY: A HISTORICAL ANALYSIS OF NIGERIAN ELECTORAL ENGAGEMENT IN THE FOURTH REPUBLIC

Dr. Onuk Bulus Ojem, Prof.Phemelo OlifileMarumo; North-West University

3:15pm-3:30pm

- ROLE OF UBUNTU PHILOSOPHY IN STRENGTHENING DEMOCRATIC GOVERNANCE IN AFRICA

Thabang Motswaledi and Johannes Madingwaneng

3:30pm-3:45pm

- BEYOND ELECTRIFICATION: TOWARDS A TRANSFORMATIVE ENERGY JUSTICE FRAMEWORK FOR ADDRESSING HISTORICAL INEQUALITIES IN SOUTH AFRICA

Ishmael Iwara & Victor Ojakorotu; North-west University

3:45pm–4:00pm

- HOW CAN WE DISMANTLE AFROPHOBIA? REIMAGINING AFROCENTRIC CITIZENSHIP EDUCATION

Tsoaledi Daniel Thobejane, Hlako Choma and Vhuhwavho Rannditsheni University of Venda Rannditsheni Attorneys Inc

4:00pm–4:15pm

- REVISITING HUMAN RIGHTS AND PEOPLE LIVING WITH ALBINISM

Bada, Bukola Victoria (PHD): University of Lagos

4:15pm-4:30pm

- DEMOCRACY AND SECURITY IN NIGERIA: THE WAY FORWARD

GLO 001
DEMOCRACY AND SECURITY IN NIGERIA: THE WAY FORWARD

Bada, Bukola Victoria (PHD)

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ABSTRACT

The Nigerian state confronts a paradox that defines its present condition. Twenty-six years after the return to constitutional rule, the country is at once Africa's largest electoral democracy and one of its most insecure polities. Boko Haram and ISWAP in the north-east, banditry across the north-west, farmer-herder violence in the middle belt, separatist agitation in the south- east, and a national epidemic of kidnapping for ransom that respects neither zone nor income bracket have produced a security landscape that progressively constrains the operational space of democratic citizenship. The 2023 general elections recorded a voter turnout of 26.7% the lowest in the Fourth Republic's history. Drawing on an empirical review of peer- reviewed scholarship, conflict incident data, and policy documents covering the period 2015–2025, this paper examines the recursive relationship between democracy and security in Nigeria. The analysis is organised around three questions: how insecurity has reshaped democratic practice; how democratic governance has responded; and whether the present trajectory permits the consolidation of either. The paper finds that successive responses to the security crisis have routinely bypassed democratic norms, deepening the legitimacy deficit that drives insecurity in the first place. It advances a five-component reform agenda namely; police decentralisation, civil-military rebalancing, electoral integrity strengthening, inclusive economic policy, and structured community security partnerships as the basis of a credible way forward. The paper contributes to ongoing scholarly and policy debates by integrating the conflict-data, electoral, and institutional literatures into a single analytical frame.

Keywords: Banditry, Democracy, Electoral integrity. Insecurity, Nigeria

GLO 002

PROTECT OR PERISH: NAMING AND SHAMING, HUMAN RIGHTS DIPLOMACY, AND THE GLOBAL BARGAINING POLITICS OF NIGERIA.AS 'COUNTRY OF CONCERN' DESIGNATION

Grace Olubunmi BABALOLA, Ph.D, FCAI, FCIPM, FIPMLD

Deputy Registrar (Academic),

Adekunle Ajasin University, Akungba-Akoko,

Ondo State,Nigeria

ABSTRACT

The United States' designation of Nigeria as a "Country of Concern" reanimates an enduring debate about the instrumentalization of human rights in global diplomacy. Framed as a humanitarian safeguard, the "naming and shaming" strategy often functions as a geopolitical bargaining tool, transforming moral advocacy into a form of soft coercion.

This paper interrogates the paradox of protection versus politicization that emerges when international concern becomes a mechanism of negotiation rather than reform. Using Nigeria's armed conflict landscape as a case study, the analysis situates the designation within broader discourses of human rights diplomacy, sovereignty, and international legitimacy. Drawing on reports from the U.S. Commission on International Religious Freedom (USCIRF), United Nations frameworks, and Nigeria's domestic security policies, the paper explores how such designations recalibrate foreign aid relations, counterinsurgency priorities, and reputational politics.

The study argues that "naming and shaming" in the Global South risks converting rights violations into diplomatic currency—where compliance becomes transactional and justice becomes negotiable. Ultimately, it contends that sustainable protection requires more than punitive labelling; it demands equitable global engagement that reinforces local accountability without reproducing dependency. Nigeria's experience thus exemplifies the new moral economy of international relations—one where human right, once a shield for the vulnerable, increasingly serve as a bargaining chip in the theatre of global power.

Keywords: Armed Conflict; Diplomacy; Global Governance; Human Rights; International Legitimacy; Nigeria; Naming and Shaming; Sovereignty; United States; US Commission on International Religious Freedom (USCIRF)

GLO 003

THE POLITICAL ECONOMY OF ENTREPRENEURSHIP: STRENGTHENING DEMOCRATIC RESILIENCE THROUGH INCLUSIVE ECONOMIC AGENCY

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Prof Ravinder Rena
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ABSTRACT

This paper explores the symbiotic relationship between democratic stability and entrepreneurial freedom within the African political economy. Amidst a global trend of democratic backsliding, the study examines how economic agency serves as a vital pillar for sustaining democratic institutions and preventing a return to illiberalism. Africa's "second independence" has been hampered by a political economy that often excludes the majority from meaningful participation. The primary problem is that without inclusive entrepreneurial opportunities, democracy is perceived as a "farce" by the populace, making societies vulnerable to populist rhetoric and military interventions. The study seeks to analyse how entrepreneurship can be used to re-tune democracy to yield popular development. It investigates the role of the state in creating an "equal playing field" that allows for the emergence of a robust, independent middle class capable of holding democratic institutions accountable. Adopting a qualitative methodology, the research accesses extensive secondary sources, including African Union policy documents, World Economic Forum insights, and development studies literature (2010–2025). Comparative analysis is used to trace the link between ease of entrepreneurship and democratic longevity. Results demonstrate that inclusive entrepreneurship acts as a buffer against democratic reversal by diversifying power and reducing state-dependency. Yet, structural obstacles such as limited access to credit and geopolitical uncertainty continue to stifle the transformative potential of the African entrepreneurial class. To overcome democratic reversal, the study recommends restructuring policy systems to prioritise innovation-based empowerment programs. The way forward lies in fostering a political economy where entrepreneurship and social justice are mutually reinforcing, ensuring a sustainable and democratic future for the continent.

Keywords: Political Economy; Democratic Resilience; Economic Agency; Inclusive Capitalism; Institutional Quality

GLO 004

BEYOND AGOA: ASSESSING CHINA'S ROLE AS A POSSIBLE SUBSTITUTE FOR AFRICAN BENEFICIARIES

Theme: China, Democracy, and Alternative Development Models

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ABSTRACT

The expiration of the African Growth Opportunity Act (AGOA) on the 2025 September 30 marked the end of an important chapter for US-Africa trade. For over 25 years, AGOA offered African states duty free access to the US markets and further concretising Washington investment in the continent. This then begs the question of what does it mean for Africa especially at a time when AfCFTA is taking off? Not only that, what then would be the role of China which is already the continent's largest trading partner? This article seeks to examine whether or not China can be regarded as a substitute to the then African beneficiaries of AGOA. Of course, noting how Beijing never pronounced itself as a replacement of the US amid the current trading gap, the article then assesses China's current trading behaviours and investments in the continent vis-à-vis, its critiques shortcomings of "dumping" finished goods and "debt trap" narratives. As such, the author argue that China can simply be regarded as the envisioned alternative to further intensify Global South relations and in particular, Africa's AfCFTA project for a full consolidation of African continental integration.

Keywords: AfCFTA, Africa, AGOA, China, United States of America, Trade

GLO 005

EXPLORING PERCEPTIONS OF RURAL YOUTH'S PARTICIPATION IN POLITICAL ELECTIONS: A CASE STUDY OF THULAMELA MUNICIPALITY.

Musa Mphegi and Rendani Tshifhumulo
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ABSTRACT

Since the end of apartheid in 1994, South Africa has held elections every five years to promote democratic engagement and allow citizens to choose their representatives. Despite this democratic foundation, the political landscape revealed a concerning trend: South African youth increasingly showed little interest in participating in political processes, particularly elections. This study investigated voter apathy among South African youth, focusing specifically on factors influencing disengagement among rural youth. Using a phenomenological approach, the research analysed the 2021 local government elections and revealed significant apathy among young voters, undermining the principles of participatory democracy. Utilizing qualitative research methods, the study incorporated both primary and secondary data collection techniques, including interviews and document analysis. Purposive sampling was used to select 18 youth from the Thulamela municipality, enabling a focused examination of their attitudes and behaviours regarding electoral participation.

Thematic analysis was employed to explore findings from recorded interviews, providing insights into rural youth's experiences and perceptions of elections. Ultimately, this study aimed to contribute to the understanding of youth voter apathy in rural areas and to propose actionable recommendations to enhance electoral engagement. The findings reveal a complex interplay of socio-economic factors and personal beliefs that shape the political attitudes of rural youth. By focusing on the lived experiences of these young individuals, the research highlights the distinctive challenges they face in the political arena and offers valuable insights into the broader implications of youth participation in democratic processes. This approach not only enriches understanding of the phenomenon but also underscores the importance of incorporating marginalized groups' perspectives into electoral discourse.

Keywords: Youths, Elections, Voter apathy, participation, electoral democracy

GLO 006

DIASPORA, DIGITAL AGE, AND DEMOCRACY: A HISTORICAL ANALYSIS OF NIGERIAN ELECTORAL ENGAGEMENT IN THE FOURTH REPUBLIC

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ABSTRACT
Nigerian diaspora has emerged as a noticeable actor in the Fourth Republic (1999-20230 principally through remittances and the rise of the digital platforms such as X (formerly Twitter) and Nairaland. This group of 'patriots' overseas have become 'watchdogs' in elections which may take the form of protests in their host countries as they constantly seek deeper connections to their homeland through mediums such as sports, festivals and electoral commentaries. This paper employs a qualitative desktop research methodology, analyzing academic literature, policy documents, diaspora- led media archives, and reports from civil society organizations to historicize and assess this engagement. It aims to evaluate the tangible impact of this engagement on electoral integrity, voter awareness, and political accountability in Nigeria and to analyse the inherent tensions and limitations of transnational democratic activism. The paper questions the possibility and necessity of diaspora voting which has gained attention recently. Preliminary findings indicate that diaspora contributions have transitioned from passive remittance support to active, real-time digital advocacy and technical election monitoring. The study concludes that while the Nigerian diaspora has become an indispensable, innovative force for democratic deepening, its ultimate effectiveness remains contingent on synergistic partnerships with domestic institutions, highlighting a complex narrative of agency and limitation in Nigeria's democratic journey.

Keywords: Diaspora, Digital age, Democracy, Fourth Republic, elections

GLO 007
ENTREPRENEURIAL GOVERNANCE: RETOOLING LOCAL ADMINISTRATION FOR SUSTAINABLE ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT IN AFRICA

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ABSTRACT
In the wake of global democratic reversal, the role of local government in fostering development has become critical. This study investigates the intersection of public administration and entrepreneurship as a strategy to revitalise local governance. It stems from the need to move beyond traditional bureaucratic models toward a more participatory and entrepreneurial approach to local service delivery. Local government administrations in many African nations struggle with inefficiency and a lack of economic vitality. This disconnects between governance and the local entrepreneurial ecosystem creates a "development gap" that fuels discontent with democratic processes, often leading to political instability. The research aims to evaluate how democratising local administration through entrepreneurial partnerships can enhance sustainable development. It seeks to establish a framework where local governance acts as an enabler for small and medium enterprises (SMEs), thereby strengthening the democratic contract at the grassroots level. Using a qualitative secondary-data design, this study examines public policy reports, local government indices, and scholarship on African development (2018– 2025). Thematic analysis is employed to synthesise best practices in "entrepreneurial governance" across diverse African regions. Findings indicate that when local administrations adopt entrepreneurial strategies such as simplified licensing and inclusive public-private partnerships they foster greater civic engagement and economic resilience. However, centralised political structures and institutional corruption remain significant barriers to this democratisation. The study recommends that African states decentralise economic decision-making and retool local government officials with entrepreneurial competencies. Strengthening these institutions is essential to ensure that democracy yields tangible development dividends for local communities.

Keywords: Local Governance; Entrepreneurial Governance; Public-Private Partnerships (PPP); Sustainable Development; Grassroots Democratisation

GLO 008

ARCHITECTURE OF DISPOSSESSION: STRUCTURALISM, LEGAL POSITIVISM, NATIVES LAND ACT 1913 AND THE POLITICAL ECONOMY OF DEMOCRATIC TRANSFORMATION IN SOUTH AFRICA

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ABSTRACT

This article critically explores the enduring influence of apartheid-era legislative mechanisms on land reform in post-apartheid South Africa, against the backdrop of a global democratic reversal in which formal democratic institutions increasingly fail to deliver substantive socio- economic transformation. Employing Structuralist and Post-Structuralist frameworks, alongside legal philosophies such as positivism and natural law, the study highlights how historical laws, specifically the Natives Land Act of 1913, have perpetuated racial and socio-economic inequalities despite constitutional reforms. By situating land reform within South Africa's democratic project, the paper demonstrates how political equality under constitutional democracy has unfolded alongside the preservation of an inherited political-economic order rooted in racialised property relations. It thus argues that the limits of land reform reflect not a failure of democratic ideals per se, but the structural entrenchment of economic power that mediates and constrains democratic decision-making. Additionally, it critically analyzes the juridico-political landscape, explores the constraints imposed by global neoliberalism on the African National Congress's transformative agenda, highlighting tensions between constitutional ideals and economic realities. Through historical-legal analysis and engagement with key cases such as Goedgelegen Tropical Fruits, Maledu, and Alexkor, judicial willingness to acknowledge historical injustice while remaining constrained by proceduralism, legal certainty, and global economic orthodoxy is illuminated. The analysis concludes that meaningful transformation requires not only legislative overhaul, but also a reconfiguration of global political-economic structures influencing domestic lawmaking, and advocates for interdisciplinary research to address these complex challenges effectively.

Keywords: Democracy; Structuralism; Legal Positivism, Natives Land Act; Transformative Constitutionalism.

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GLO 009

Digital Media Exposure and Democratic Backsliding Among Young Women in Lagos, Nigeria: The Mediating Roles of Political Trust and Political Apathy

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Abstract

Democracy has witnessed a severe backslide in developing societies like Nigeria in recent years. In Nigeria, digital platforms such as X (formerly Twitter), Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, and online news outlets have become major channels for political information, shaping citizens' perceptions of governance and democratic institutions. The study's main objective is to examine the relationship between digital media exposure and democratic backsliding among young women in Lagos, Nigeria, with a particular focus on the mediating roles of political trust and political apathy. The study is anchored in the Media Dependency Theory and Political Trust Theory. It proposes that digital media exposure influences democratic attitudes both directly and indirectly through changes in trust in political institutions and in levels of political apathy. It was hypothesised that (a) digital media exposure significantly influences perceptions of democratic backsliding among young women; (b) Political trust and apathy mediate the relationship between digital media exposure and perceptions of democratic backsliding among young women in Lagos, Nigeria. A cross-sectional survey design was employed to collect data from young women aged 18–35 residing in Lagos State using a self-designed questionnaire. Data were analysed using Structural Equation Modelling (SEM) to evaluate the direct and indirect relationships among the study variables and to test the proposed mediation model. The results indicated that digital media exposure had a significant positive effect on perceptions of democratic backsliding among young women in Lagos ($\beta = 0.42$, $t = 7.83$, $p < .001$). The model explained 17.6% of the variance in perceptions of democratic backsliding ($R^2 = .176$). While greater exposure to digital media tends to erode political trust and increase political apathy, which in turn heightens perceptions of democratic decline. This study concludes that digital media exposure significantly shapes perceptions of democratic backsliding among young women in Lagos, Nigeria.

Keywords: Digital Media Exposure, Democratic Backsliding, Political Trust, Political Apathy, Young Women.

GLO 010

EXPLORING DEMOCRACY ANDDEVELOPMENT: THE CONNECTION BETWEEN ENGLISH LANGUAGE ANDWOMEN'S EMPOWERMENT INAFRICA

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ABSTRACT

This study examines the intricate relationship between English language proficiency, women's empowerment, and democratic development in Africa. As the continent navigates the complexities of democratic governance and economic growth, the role of the English language in shaping women's experiences and opportunities cannot be overstated. Underpinned by Semilore Sobande's Black Feminist theory and using a qualitative approach, complemented by an ethnographic research design conducted over six months, this study explored the connection between democracy and development, as well as the relationship between the English language and women's empowerment in Africa. The population of this study comprised 152 women employed in the African government. Fifteen (15) women were purposefully sampled to participate in the study. Through a critical analysis of existing literature and empirical evidence, this study highlights the ways in which English language proficiency can facilitate women's access to education, economic opportunities, and political participation. The study also explores the challenges and opportunities that arise from the intersection of language, politics, and socio-economic development, and argues that language policies can play a critical role in promoting more inclusive and equitable development outcomes. The findings of this study have implications for policymakers, educators, and development practitioners seeking to promote women's empowerment and democratic development in Africa. The study argues for English language support programmes to help women access education, employment, and services more effectively.

Keywords: Africa, democracy, development, English, women's empowerment

GLO 011

NEGOTIATING EQUITY AND PEACE THROUGH "POWER": THE IMPACTFUL ROLE OF TEACHER UNIONS BETWEEN THE ERA OF STRUGGLE AND RECONCILIATION IN UNJUST SCHOOL SYSTEMS

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ABSTRACT
The ensuing article examines the tensions and groundbreaking potential characteristic in teacher union involvement within historically established school governance schools. This article utilizes empirical data from South African public ordinary schools to examine how teacher unions balance their resistance to systemic injustices with their involvement in pursuing reconciliatory educational changes. This research, grounded in peacebuilding and social justice frameworks, examines the role of teacher unions as mediators of peace and equity in fragmented and socio-politically contested contexts. The study employed a qualitative research approach, involving 16 purposely selected participants: principals (n=4), school management team (SMT) members (n=4), school governing body (SGB) members (n=4), and teacher union representatives (n=4). Data were collected via semi-structured individual interviews and thematically examined to discern occurring themes and patterns related to advocacy, institutional negotiation, and contestation. Findings indicated that teacher unions strive to avoid perceptions of hostility towards official compliance and aim to be regarded as equal partners in restorative educational justice. In the absence of ideological alignment, mutual trust and policy literacy coexisted; teacher unions significantly contribute to equity-driven initiatives and context-sensitive peacebuilding in educational institutions. However, in the absence of dialogic leadership and inclusive frameworks, teacher union participation threatened to exacerbate existing alienation and societal divisions. This study concludes by reconceptualizing teacher union agency as dynamic forces rather than antagonistic ones, placed within broader socio-political negotiations. Therefore, it is recommended that there be a reconstruction of policy mandates, relational leadership models, and an enhancement of union-policy interactions to support and reinforce inclusive governance and transformative peace.

Keywords: Democratic accountability; Educational equity; Institutional theory; Peacebuilding; Power negotiation; post-conflict education system; School governance; Teacher Union

GLO 012

THE DIGITAL FRONTLINE: MEDIA PLURALISM AND DEVELOPMENT IN THE AGE OF "INFODEMICS" AND MEDIA CAPTURE

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ABSTRACT
This study investigates the critical tension between media as a driver for socio-economic development and the systemic "capture" of digital infrastructures by illiberal regimes within the context of global democratic reversal. The purpose is to analyse how the monetisation of disinformation, internet shutdowns, and regulatory suppression impacts the business sustainability of independent media and, by extension, national development goals. Adopting a qualitative secondary research design, the methodology synthesises reports from the Media Institute of Southern Africa (MISA), World Bank development indicators, and platform governance studies spanning 2020 to 2025. Analytical tools include political economy of communication, media sustainability metrics, and econometric modeling of ad-revenue loss during state-mandated shutdowns. The findings reveal that media capture and platform taxation not only erode democratic participation but also create a "risk premium" that deters foreign direct investment and stalls innovation ecosystems. Conversely, the study identifies that independent media houses and digital creators are demonstrating adaptive business models, such as audience-funded journalism and data-driven storytelling, that sustain both civic trust and economic viability. Social media platforms emerge as contested spaces where youth-led counter-narratives challenge state disinformation while stimulating creative labor markets. Implications underscore that media pluralism is not merely a political necessity but a prerequisite for a stable market economy and "digital sovereignty." Stakeholders include media entrepreneurs, telecommunications companies, technology firms, and international development agencies. The study contributes to the body of knowledge by linking democratic resilience to media market sustainability, positioning media freedom as a critical business infrastructure. Its originality stems from quantifying the economic cost of democratic erosion through the lens of media pluralism and digital trade.

Keywords: Media Pluralism, Digital Development, Infodemics, Economic Sovereignty, Democratic Resilience.

GLO 013

FRAMES OF RESISTANCE: AFRICAN CINEMA AS A BULWARK AGAINST AUTOCRATIC CREEP AND MARKET MONOPOLY

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ABSTRACT

This research examines the intersection of cinematic activism and the political economy of film as a vital defense mechanism against democratic backsliding in Africa. The purpose of the study is to evaluate how contemporary African filmmakers deploy narrative satire and documentary practice to challenge authoritarian drift while simultaneously navigating a business landscape dominated by state-aligned distribution networks and global market pressures. Adopting a qualitative methodology based on secondary data, synthesising film industry reports, box office analytics, festival catalogues, and human rights indices from 2020 to 2025, the study utilises tools such as thematic content analysis, political economy frameworks, and market-share benchmarking. The research timeframe captures the post-pandemic surge in digital streaming and the concurrent rise in "third-termism" across the continent. Findings indicate that independent African cinema has successfully pivoted to global Video-on- Demand (VOD) platforms to bypass local censorship, creating a sustainable business model for "dissident art" that ensures both financial viability and global advocacy. The study reveals that political satire serves as a commercially viable strategy for bypassing state crackdowns, while documentary film functions as evidentiary media for institutional accountability. Implications suggest that the film industry serves as a primary engine for both democratic discourse and cultural export revenue, strengthening domestic creative value chains against autocratic normalisation. Key stakeholders include independent producers, digital platform regulators, investors, and civil society organisations. This study contributes to the body of knowledge by reframing African cinema as a democratic infrastructure with measurable economic impact. Its uniqueness lies in its analysis of "the business of dissent," proving that reclaiming local narrative authority is a profitable prerequisite for inclusive development and a resilient creative economy.

Keywords: Cinematic Activism, Democratic Backsliding, Creative Industries, VOD Distribution, Media Economics.

GLO 014
NATURAL RESOURCES, OIL POLITICS AND DEMOCRACY IN NIGERIA

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ABSTRACT
Natural resources, especially oil, play a prominent role in advancing the development path of countries across the globe. However, cases equally abound where natural resources have contributed negatively, and this portrays grave consequences for the people and the entire nation. One such continent is Africa, and particularly Nigeria, where several pundits have alluded to the presence of a resource curse, which has further thrown up emerging and contending issues across the country. Though studies have alluded to the fact that the availability of oil has become a source of conflict, inequality, and instability, critical reflections underscore the need for broad interrogation of the significance of oil to the politics and democracy of Nigeria. Using secondary sources, this study examines the possible usefulness of oil as a factor of societal solidarity as compared to allusions from pundits. Experiences from the key players in the oil sector expose the fact that though oil politics in Nigeria has so many negative consequences, oil remains a major factor uniting the various states and people in Nigeria. Further, the kind of revenue generation accruable to Nigeria ensures that political actors prefer to align with the established order by tacitly supporting democracy to keep the Nigerian state as one. This mindset establishes that beyond the negativity associated with oil politics, it has equally contributed to the democratization and stability of the Nigerian state.

Key words: Natural Resources, Oil, Politics, Actors, Democracy, Nigeria

GLO 015

WORK, DEMOCRACY, AND SOCIAL INCLUSION IN AFRICA: MAINSTREAMING WOMEN'S PARTICIPATION FOR DEMOCRATIC RENEWAL AND DEVELOPMENT

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ABSTRACT

Across Africa, democracy has long been promoted as a pathway to political stability and socioeconomic development. However, recent democratic reversals, rising populism, and renewed authoritarian tendencies have exposed fundamental weaknesses in democratic institutions on the continent. Central to these challenges is the persistent exclusion of women from both political decision-making and the structures of productive work that shape democratic life. This paper examines the interconnected relationship between work, democracy, and social inclusion in Africa, with a specific focus on the mainstreaming of women's participation as a strategy for democratic renewal and sustainable development.

Drawing on democratic theory, feminist political economy, and empirical evidence from African states, the study argues that meaningful democracy extends beyond periodic elections to include equitable access to political power, decent work, and economic agency. Women's participation in paid and unpaid work, labour markets, governance institutions, and political leadership is shown to be critical for strengthening democratic accountability, policy responsiveness, and social cohesion. Yet, structural barriers such as patriarchal norms, unequal labour divisions, limited access to resources, and exclusionary political systems continue to marginalise women across the continent. The paper contends that mainstreaming women's participation in both work and democratic processes can reinvigorate African democracy by deepening representation, enhancing institutional legitimacy, and aligning governance outcomes with citizens' lived realities. It concludes that democratic renewal in Africa depends on integrated policy approaches that promote gender-inclusive labour markets, supportive welfare systems, and institutional reforms that enable women's full participation in political life. By foregrounding women's work and agency, African democracies can better fulfill their developmental promise.

Keywords: Democracy, Development in Africa, Social Inclusion, Women's Political Participation, Work and Labour

GLO 016

BEYOND FLAG INDEPENDENCE: PAN-AFRICANISM, POLITICAL ECONOMY AND DEMOCRATIC SOVEREIGNTY IN AFRICA

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ABSTRACT

More than sixty years following the political independence of many African states, the ideal of democratic self-determination remains constrained by lasting colonial legacies. Formal independence, symbolised by national flags and electoral rituals, has often failed to translate into genuine democratic sovereignty. The colonial-era political institutions, economic dependencies, and epistemological frameworks continue to shape governance practices, development trajectories, and the limits of democratic agency across the continent. This article examines these enduring "shadows of the colonial past" and argues that Africa's contemporary democratic challenges cannot be fully understood outside their political-economic foundations. Drawing on the Pan-African thought, ranging from Kwame Nkrumah's critique of neo- colonialism to current initiatives by the African Union, such as Agenda 2063 and the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA), this paper examines Pan-Africanism both as a critical response to post-colonial continuities and as a framework for reimagining democratic sovereignty in Africa. Methodologically, this study adopts a historical-institutionalist approach to trace how colonial governance structures have been reproduced within post-independence democratic systems, while also engaging with contemporary discussions surrounding economic justice, digital sovereignty, and regional integration in a multipolar world marked by democratic reversal. The paper argues that revitalising Pan-Africanism beyond rhetorical solidarity is essential for dismantling structural dependencies, deepening democratic legitimacy, and strengthening Africa's collective agency in global political and economic affairs. In doing so, it reframes Pan- Africanism not merely as a historical liberation ideology but as a transformative political-economic initiative central to the pursuit of democratic development and genuine sovereignty in twenty-first-century Africa.

Keywords: Pan-Africanism; Flag Independence; Democratic Sovereignty; Political Economy; Colonial Legacies; Decolonisation.

GLO 017
DIGITALIZING ELECTIONS: PRIVATE SECTOR, TECHNOLOGY AND DEMOCRACY IN WEST AFRICA

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ABSTRACT
This study examines the possible digitalization of democracy in Africa far beyond the conventional narratives. Specifically, it explores how the corporate private sector advancement in technology could be deployed in improving electoral systems and outcomes in Africa, especially in West Africa. Since the third wave of democracy, which forced many authoritarian regimes into opening up the political space of their countries, the democratic practices of these countries have been met with mixed feelings. Concerns about poor electoral outcomes have necessitated the need for electoral reforms, including digital technology, to enhance electoral outcomes. However, recent experiences suggest that many nations in Africa, especially in West Africa, have struggled with digitalizing elections, and this has been blamed for election-related violence across the region. A much greater concern is the inability of electoral bodies and the public sector to effectively harness the potentials of digital technology despite its significance in today's global system. Therefore, it is compelling to reflect on the digital technology growth of the private sector in West Africa and what possible lessons can be transferred into the public sector to aid election management in West Africa. Diffusion of innovation theory, secondary, and primary sources would be used for this study.

Keywords: Elections: Private Sector, Technology, Democracy, West Africa

GLO 018

DEMOCRATIC GOVERNANCE FOR SOCIAL JUSTICE IN AFRICAN COUNTRIES. A CASE OF SOUTH AFRICA.

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ABSTRACT

The aim of this paper is to analyse the effects of democratic governance on social justice in African countries in the context of South Africa. Good governance and accountability are considered as critical pillars for the African countries to underscore reliable democracy and development. It is observed that good governance promotes respect for human rights, the rule of law, public participation in policy implementation, as well as effective provision of social justice to the citizens. However, democratic governance for social justice in African countries, particularly in South Africa is confronted with major challenges, which its legitimacy becomes highly questionable. Hence, this paper sought to analyse the effects of democratic governance in the context of African countries. This paper has adopted conceptual framework and used literature to analyse the effects of democratic governance in African countries. In the process, literature revealed that the democratic governance in African countries is characterized by pervasive corruption, weak rule of law, political instability, lack of accountability, poor leadership, ineffective public service delivery, inadequate resources, as well as lack of public participation in government projects. Literature further showed that these challenges are seen as stumbling blocks towards development and effective provision of social justice to the citizens. The literature also highlighted key issues such as state capture, prejudice, lack of transparency, poor conflict management, poor technological infrastructures, and rooted systemic issues. This Paper conclude by proposing conceptual framework for good democratic governance to bring about effective social justice to the citizens.

Key words: Democratic governance, social justice, good governance, accountability and African countries.

GLO 019

PEOPLE-CENTRED GOVERNANCE: A RESOURCE FOR CURBING IMPERSONATION AND UNETHICAL CONDUCT IN JOHANNESBURG'S REAL ESTATE SECTOR

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ABSTRACT

Johannesburg, a megacity in South Africa, faces a growing incidence of criminal practices targeting municipal service delivery and real estate operations, including impersonation of City Power/municipal officials, illegal disconnections and reconnections, meter tampering/theft, and extortion. Recent arrests—some involving contractor-linked personnel and interns—illustrate systemic vulnerabilities in administrative transparency, identity verification, and public oversight. This paper proposed a governance and civic tech framework for the democratisation of local government administration—emphasising open data, digital verification, public participation, and community co oversight—to narrow the opportunity space for these crimes while advancing sustainable urban development.

It synthesises current events in the city with comparative evidence from governance research showing that digitalisation and open data improve transparency and reduce corruption risks when accompanied by inclusive institutional design, external supervision, and civil society engagement. It further links democratic governance to sustainable development outcomes via improved municipal finances, infrastructure reliability, and investor confidence. The paper concludes with a policy and implementation roadmap, evaluation metrics, and limitations.

Keywords: Democratising CoJ, Illegal Disconnections, Meter Theft, Extortion, Real Estate Sector

GLO 020
DEMOCRACY AND THE POLITICS OF PROTEST (DE) LEGITIMISATION IN NIGERIA

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ABSTRACT
This article employs a pathways framework to analyze the process and resistance of democratic backsliding in Nigeria since 1999. It addresses three core questions: the extent of backsliding, the processes through which it occurs, and the conditions for effective resistance. We argue that Nigeria's experience is not characterized by a single pathway, but by a confluence of executive aggrandizement through legislative capture, plebiscitary majoritarianism, and direct executive power grabs—and a more insidious elite collusion, where bipartisan pacts undermine accountability without centralizing all power. Empirically, we trace backsliding's extent across key institutions like the judiciary, electoral commission (INEC), and media, identifying accelerated erosion post-2015. The process analysis reveals that while executive aggrandizement targets formal institutional checks, elite collusion operates through the informal "zoning" system and bipartisan corruption, dispersing culpability and complicating resistance. The article then evaluates resistance strategies including judicial challenges, civil society mobilization (e.g., #EndSARS), and opposition coalition-building within the constraints of these pathways. We find that resistance is most effective when it exploits institutional arenas still possessing residual legitimacy (e.g., the courts) and is backed by sustained, broad-based popular mobilization. However, the elite collusion pathway creates a critical dilemma for opposition actors, often forcing a choice between upholding democratic principles and participating in a compromised system to access patronage. The analysis contributes to the literature on democratic erosion by demonstrating how formal institutional degradation and informal elite collusion interact in a competitive authoritarian context, and by specifying the conditional and often partial nature of democratic resistance in such an environment.

Keywords: Democratic Backsliding, Nigeria, Executive Aggrandizement, Elite Collusion, Democratic Resistance

GLO 021

SUFFERING IN SILENCE: A CASE OF GENDER-BASED VIOLENCE AGAINST MEN'S WELL-BEING AT KWAAI-DRAAI VILLAGE, LIMPOPO PROVINCE (SOUTH AFRICA)

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ABSTRACT
The paper focused on the effects of gender-based violence against men's well-being in Kwaai Draai village, Limpopo Province. It examined a variety of factors leading to gender-based violence (GBV) and its consequences against men in Kwaai Draai village. The paper will use a sociological lens to explore gender-based violence against men within a family set-up. GBV is a global pandemic in which women and children are solely assumed to be victims due to their vulnerability, whilst, in contrast, men are subjected to suffering in silence in the same patriarchal societies. The paper is a qualitative, exploratory study. The snowball sampling method was used to select participants. Semi-structured interviews were used to solicit data from participants. In its integration, the study used social learning theory. The findings emphasized that law enforcement personnel and community and sector dialogue campaigns should begin to take matters seriously if men are affected and come forward to report cases of IPV. The findings also highlight that little has been written about GBV in males as compared to women and children.

Keywords: Emotional Violence, Gender-Based Violence (GBV), Intimate Partner Violence IPV), Physical Violence, coercive control, Well-being.

GLO 022

THEORETICAL UNDERPINNINGS OF THE DECLINE OF DEMOCRACY IN AFRICA: LIBRARY CONSIDERATION

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ABSTRACT
The decline of democracy in Africa has emerged as a pressing issue that necessitates a comprehensive exploration of its theoretical underpinnings. This paper investigates the multifaceted factors contributing to this decline, with a particular emphasis on the role of libraries and information access in shaping democratic processes. Libraries, as vital repositories of knowledge, play a crucial role in fostering informed citizenry, promoting civic engagement, and supporting the free exchange of ideas. Therefore, this paper aims to contribute to the comprehensive discussion on democratic flexibility in Africa, emphasising the transformative potential of libraries in reversing the trends of democratic decline. The study will use the literature review methodology to enable the collection and synthesizing of previous research, integrating findings and perspectives from other empirical findings. However, the degradation of library resources, censorship, and restricted access to information in many African countries have profound implications for democratic participation. By employing theoretical frameworks related to democracy, knowledge dissemination, and social capital, this study elucidates how the erosion of library functions correlates with the deterioration of democratic norms. The study recommend that, strengthening library infrastructures as a means to reinvigorate democratic values, enhancing public awareness, and cultivate a culture of accountability and transparency should be advocated.

Keywords: digital technology, digital information, Ethnic divisions, social inequality, library resources, civic participation

GLO 023
ROLE OF UBUNTU PHILOSOPHY INSTRENGTHENING DEMOCRATIC GOVERNANCEIN AFRICA

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ABSTRACT
Democratic governance in Africa continues to face challenges, including weak institutional structures, corruption, limited citizen participation, electoral conflicts, and accountability deficits. Despite the adoption of democratic systems across many African states, sustainable governance remains constrained by political instability and governance inefficiencies. This study examines the role of Ubuntu philosophy in strengthening democratic governance in Africa. Ubuntu, rooted in African ethical thought, emphasises human dignity, collective responsibility, solidarity, mutual respect, and inclusive decision-making, which are essential principles for effective governance.
The study adopts a qualitative research design, relying on secondary data sources such as scholarly articles, policy documents, and institutional reports. The analysis is anchored on African Communitarian Theory and participatory governance theory as its theoretical framework. Findings indicate that Ubuntu philosophy promotes dialogue, consensus-building, reconciliation, and social cohesion, which contribute to democratic stability. However, its application in formal governance systems remains largely symbolic rather than institutionalised. The study concludes that incorporating Ubuntu principles into democratic processes can strengthen governance effectiveness and political legitimacy in Africa. It recommends integrating indigenous ethical values into constitutional reforms, public administration, and civic engagement mechanisms to enhance democratic consolidation.

Keywords: Ubuntu philosophy, Democratic governance, African political systems Citizen participation, Institutional Accountability. Etc

GLO 024

LEGITIMACY OF POWER: NIGER'S DEMOCRACY BACKSLIDE AND THE MESSIANIC MILITARY JUNTA

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ABSTRACT

The political landscape of Niger has been characterized by frequent instability, and has seen several military coups since independence in 1960. This paper delves into the complex interplay between democratic governance and military coups in Niger, through the lens of legitimacy of power. It explores the concept and claims of legitimate power by the military junta who overthrow the democratically elected regimes. By analyzing the July 2023 coup led by General Abdourahamane Tchiani, this paper breaks down the justifications provided by the military for their putsch. Some of these claims include government corruption, insecurity in the Sahel, and the need to restore Niger's sovereignty. Additionally, this paper scrutinizes the post-coup rhetoric deployed by the junta in a bid to gain performance legitimacy and take on the frame of messianic liberators of Niger. Through a critical analysis of the interplay of all these factors, this paper aims to provide a nuanced understanding of the claim to legitimate power in Niger, and the future implications for its democracy. This analysis will provide relevance to contemporary political philosophy through its examination of how notions of legitimacy of power are constructed and contested in volatile political environments such as in Niger. The paper will be a significant contribution to the ongoing discourse about nature of power and the state, legitimate authority, and the conditions under which non-democratic regimes can claim legitimacy.

GLO 025

PERCEPTION OF GENDER RESPONSIVENESS OF THE NIGERIAN NATIONAL AGRICULTURAL EXTENSION POLICY BY AGRICULTURE PROFESSIONALS IN RIVERS STATE.

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ABSTRACT

This study accessed the perception of gender responsiveness of the Nigerian National Agricultural Extension Policy (NAEP) among agricultural professionals in Rivers State, Nigeria. A total of 131 respondents selected using two-staged sampling procedure were surveyed with the aid of structured questionnaire. Data collected were analyzed with descriptive statistics and Z-tests. Results revealed that awareness of NAEP was relatively high, as 79.4% indicated awareness of the policy, though fewer respondents were familiar with its objectives (61.0%), specific programs (44.2%), and institutional framework (49.6%). Respondents' perception of gender responsiveness recorded a pooled mean of 3.16, indicating that the policy is viewed as inclusive among the agriculture professionals in the state. The highest-rated items included recognition of women's roles in agriculture ($\bar{x}$ = 3.41) and consideration of both male and female needs ($\bar{x}$ = 3.33), while funding support ($\bar{x}$ = 2.93) and alignment with international gender agreements ($\bar{x}$ = 2.89) scored lowest. Major challenges envisaged in policy domestication were limited awareness ($\bar{x}$ = 3.38), restrictive socio-cultural norms ($\bar{x}$ = 3.35), and inadequate funding ($\bar{x}$ = 3.32). Suggested strategies for effective domestication includes inclusive stakeholder engagement ($\bar{x}$ = 3.50), resource allocation ($\bar{x}$ = 3.49), and training policymakers on gender issues ($\bar{x}$= 3.48). The Z-test showed a significant difference between male and female professionals' perceptions, with females rating NAEP as more gender responsive (Z = -2.18, $p < 0.05$). The study concludes that although NAEP is perceived as an inclusive policy, implementation gaps persist, necessitating stronger funding, awareness creation, and gender-sensitive monitoring to enhance greater inclusivity and overall effectiveness in agricultural extension services.

Keywords: Gender responsiveness, Agricultural extension policy, Agriculture Professionals, Awareness, Perception

GLO 026

DEMOCRATISING ADMINISTRATIVE PRACTICES FOR SUSTAINABLE LOCAL ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT: EVIDENCE FROM TWO MUNICIPALITIES IN SOUTH AFRICA

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ABSTRACT

Across Africa, local governments are increasingly positioned as institutional anchors of democratic governance and sustainable development. Yet, while political decentralisation has expanded the formal authority of municipalities, far less attention has been given to how democratic principles are embedded within everyday administrative practices. This paper examines how democratising local government administration shapes the sustainability and effectiveness of local economic development (LED) initiatives, with particular attention to core democratic characteristics of participation, accountability, responsiveness and equality of voice. Drawing on a qualitative comparative case study of Bergrivier Local Municipality and Cape Agulhas Local Municipality in South Africa, the study analyses institutional arrangements, participatory governance practices and intergovernmental relations as central dimensions of democratic local administration. Data were generated through semi-structured interviews and document analysis and analysed thematically. The findings show that the quality of democracy in LED implementation is determined less by the existence of participatory structures and more by the design and capacity of administrative systems. Weak internal coordination, limited organisational positioning of LED functions and constrained fiscal discretion undermine downward accountability, restrict meaningful stakeholder participation and reduce the responsiveness of development initiatives to local economic realities. While both municipalities formally comply with South Africa's national LED policy frameworks, variations in internal administrative organisation and collaborative practices significantly influence local ownership, learning and the long-term sustainability of development interventions. The paper argues that sustainable local development is constrained not by policy gaps, but by deficits in the democratisation of administrative practices. It contributes to African local governance debates by demonstrating that embedding democratic principles within routine administrative processes such as planning, budgeting and project appraisal is central to building inclusive, resilient and locally grounded development pathways.

KeyWords: Participatory Governance, Local Economic Development, Intergovernmental Relations, Fiscal Autonomy.

GLO 027

COLONIALITY, ASPIRATION AND FAMILY LANGUAGE POLICY: UNDERSTANDING PARENTS AND CAREGIVERS' COMPLEX DISPOSITIONS TOWARDS CHILDREN'S TRANSLANGUAGING

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ABSTRACT
In Africa, an enduring relic of colonialism persists through the utilisation of ex-colonial languages at the expense of indigenous African languages. In Zimbabwe, this linguistic inheritance is punctuated by the legitimisation of English, despite the constitutional recognition of multilingualism. Colonial ideologies that ameliorate English account for families' complex dispositions towards children's translanguaging practices, despite being framed as a transformative, inclusive, and empowering practice for indigenous languages. Drawing on insights from decoloniality, translanguaging and the family language policy approach, this study interrogates how selected parents' and caregivers' orientations towards children's translanguaging practices shape their family language policy. Findings reveal how the aspiration for children's acquisition of English for social and economic advantage influences parents' and caregivers' ambivalent attitudes towards translanguaging practices at home, inadvertently perpetuating coloniality within the family domain. There is a need, therefore, to emphasise the decolonial potential of translanguaging in family language policy.

Keywords: Decoloniality; family language policy; translanguaging; parents and caregivers; language practices; language ideologies

GLO 028

ADVANCING GENDER EQUALITY IN ZIMBABWEAN DEMOCRACY: ELECTORAL DESIGN OR A POLITICAL PARTY MANDATE? LESSONS FROM SOUTH AFRICA

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ABSTRACT

Since 1980, Zimbabwe has adopted a range of constitutional, legislative, and policy measures aimed at advancing gender equality in political representation, including constitutionally entrenched quota systems and affirmative action mechanisms. Despite these interventions, women remain persistently underrepresented in political and decision-making structures. This article argues that the limited success of these reforms cannot be explained solely by electoral design or constitutional guarantees, but rather by the under-examined role of political parties as primary gatekeepers of political participation. Through a doctrin al and comparative analysis, the article interrogates international, regional, and domestic legal frameworks governing women's political righ ts in Zimbabwe, with particular emphasis on the regulation and conduct of political parties. It further examines key judicial decisions that reveal the judiciary's constrained capacity to remedy gendered exclusions embedded within party politics. To deepen the analysis, the article introduces a comparative South African perspective, illustrating how a different constitutional and electoral context characterised by the absence of legislated quotas but stronger party-driven inclusion, nonetheless reinforces the centrality of political parties in shaping women's political representation.

Keywords: Gender Equality; Politics; Women; and Political Parties

GLO 029

RESOURCE COMPETITION AND POLITICAL ECOLOGY OF FARMER–HERDER CONFLICT IN NIGERIA: IMPLICATIONS FOR SUSTAINABLE PEACE

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ABSTRACT
The persistent conflict between farmers and herders in Nigeria has become a major threat to national security, food systems, and sustainable development, making it a critical issue for policy and academic inquiry. Despite extensive discourse on the subject, there remains a gap in integrative analyses that simultaneously examine the underlying causes, consequences, and sustainable resolution mechanisms within a coherent theoretical framework. This study addresses this gap by applying conflict theory and the political ecology approach to provide a comprehensive understanding of the dynamics of farmer-herder conflicts in Nigeria. The study aims to investigate the root causes of the conflict, assess its socio- economic and environmental consequences, and evaluate sustainable mechanisms for conflict resolution. A qualitative research design is adopted, relying on secondary data, historical analysis, and policy review. The analysis is grounded in theoretical insights that link resource competition, environmental change, and institutional weaknesses to conflict dynamics. The findings reveal that the conflict is driven by multiple interrelated factors, including resource scarcity, climate change, population growth, land tenure challenges, and weak governance structures. The consequences are severe, encompassing loss of lives and property, displacement, food insecurity, and economic disruption. The study also finds that existing resolution mechanisms are inadequate due to poor implementation and lack of coordination. The study concludes that a holistic, multi-level approach and community-based conflict resolution is essential for achieving sustainable peace and coexistence.

KEYWORDS: Farmers-Herders' Conflict, Resource Competition, Sustainable Peace and Political Ecology Approach

GLO 030
REALISM, DEMOCRACY, SOVEREIGNTY AND SECURITY IN AFRICA

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Abstract
In the increasingly anarchic and unpredictable international order, is the democracy, sovereignty and security of African states assured? This paper sought to examine Africa's positionality in the unstable international system. In recent times the United States (U.S.) has violated the sovereignty and security of several states, including that of Venezuela and Iran, in both instances abducting or killing the leaders of these countries. The United Nations (UN) and UN Security Council could not do anything beyond condemning the actions of the U.S. and characterizing its behaviour as amounting to violation and undermining of international law. In this milieu, the sovereignty and security of the African states cannot be viewed as guaranteed, as militarily (and economically) powerful states can decide to invade and undermine the security and sovereignty of states on the African continent. In light of this, what is to be done? The argument advanced in this paper, based on realist theory, is that military power and possibly economic power have an important role to play in safeguarding the sovereignty, security, and even democracy, of states in Africa, without which states could be in a precarious situation. None of the African states have the necessary military capability to deter a hostile foreign intervention by a global power, which essentially mean their sovereignty and security are fragile in the context of the anarchic international order.

Keywords: Africa, realism, sovereignty, security, democracy, international order, anarchy

GLO 031

EXPLORING CHALLENGES FACING EDUCATION IN MODELING DEMOCRATIC CITIZENSHIP AND GOOD GOVERNANCE IN AFRICA WITHIN THE CONTEXT OF GLOBAL DEMOCRATIC REVERSAL

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ABSTRACT

Education plays an important role in shaping democratic citizenship and promoting good governance. In Africa, educational systems are expected not only to transmit knowledge but also to cultivate civic responsibility, democratic values, and active participation in governance. However, this role is increasingly challenged by a global trend of democratic reversal, where democratic institutions are flagging in many parts of the world. In Africa, issues such corruption, weak institutional frameworks, political instability, limited civic education, and unequal access to quality education hinder the capacity of educational institutions to model democratic citizenship and good governance. This paper explores challenges facing education systems in Africa in fostering democratic citizenship and good governance within the broader context of global democratic decline. It argues that strengthening civic education, promoting critical thinking, improving governance within educational institutions, and ensuring inclusive and equitable access to education are essential steps towards addressing these challenges. The analysis is grounded in perspectives drawn from diverse contexts.

Keywords: Democratic citizenship, Good governance, Civic education, Global democratic reversal, African education systems

GLO 032

INSECURITY AND POVERTY: TWIN CHALLENGES TO ELECTION ADMINISTRATION IN NIGERIA'S FOURTH REPUBLIC

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ABSTRACT
With insecurity and poverty being major stumbling blocks in Nigeria for the undertaking of elections and thereby injuring the integrity and credibility, this qualitative study examines how they directly affect election administration in Nigeria, particularly as pertains to the Fourth Republic period (1999-present) within the purview of democratic transition theory, using secondary sources from existing works, reports, news articles taken for analysis. From the aforementioned expositions, it becomes clear how insecurity (which potentially leads to voter suppression, logistical barriers, and threats to staff safety and infrastructure) dissociates the voters from the election process while poverty is manipulated and trivialized by the political elite for use in corrupt political practices. Indeed, this union frustrates the security organs, leaves elections inconclusive, and, as a result, democratic faith will be gone with a swoosh. The study suggests that to tackle these challenges, certain adjustments regarding security-INEC relationships would be beneficial to expedite coordination and intelligence gathering capabilities and that the more advantageous option is to judicially incur any offenders caught in the web. Also recommended would be a setup of a voter educational ecosystem robust enough to denounce the influences of money and consultations, alongside specific actions to check out on electoral fraud opportunism by desperately provoking impoverished communities through a preferable move toward governmental anti-poverty measures and strong emphasis on police neutrality to restore and bolster trust in the system.

Keywords: Election administration, insecurity, poverty, democratic transition

GLO 033

DEMOCRACY, CITIZEN EDUCATION, AND LEADERSHIP CAPACITY IN AFRICA AND ITS INFLUENCE ON NIGERIAN UNIVERSITIES

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ABSTRACT

Democracy, citizen education, and leadership capacity are central to Africa's socio-political development, with Nigerian universities serving as vital institutions where these elements converge. Democracy in Africa highlights governance structures, participation, and institutional autonomy, yet its practice is often constrained by weak institutions, corruption, and political interference. Within this framework, citizen education emerges as a critical tool for fostering civic responsibility, rights awareness, and democratic culture. Nigerian universities embed these ideals through General Studies courses, political science programs, debates, and student activism, thereby equipping students with the knowledge and skills necessary for meaningful participation in governance. Leadership capacity, focusing on training, mentorship, and student union governance, is also nurtured within universities. Platforms such as Student Union Governments and campus associations provide opportunities for leadership practice, though their effectiveness is frequently undermined by inadequate funding, corruption, and external interference. University autonomy, which captures the tension between academic freedom and political influence, remains a pressing issue in Nigeria, as government involvement in leadership appointments often weakens institutional independence. Despite these challenges, Nigerian universities play a pivotal role in national development by shaping leaders and driving progress across political, economic, and social spheres. Strengthening civic education, enhancing leadership development programs, and safeguarding university autonomy are essential pathways for reform. This analysis underscores the dual role of Nigerian universities as both products and drivers of Africa's democratic and leadership landscape, highlighting their potential to foster sustainable governance and contribute to broader societal transformation.

Keywords: Democracy, Citizen Education, Leadership, Capacity, and University Autonomy

GLO 034

RECRUITMENT, GOVERNANCE, AND THE DEMOCRATISATION OF PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION: EVIDENCE FROM COMMUNITY HEALTH WORKER PROGRAMME IN SOUTH AFRICA

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ABSTRACT

This study investigated recruiting and selection practices in Community Health Worker (CHW) programs as democratic administrative processes that influence institutional capacity, worker motivation, and state legitimacy in Africa's decentralised public service delivery systems. The study, which is based on Human Resource Management theory, Human Capital Theory, and Equity Theory, views recruitment and selection as governance mechanisms for institutionalising meritocracy, justice, and accountability in the public sector. A quantitative study design was used to collect data from 257 respondents participating in the execution of CHW tasks within the Sedibeng District Municipality, South Africa. The findings show that inadequacies in recruiting and selection processes impact views of procedural fairness, weaken human capital development, and negatively affect employee motivation, performance, and retention. These administrative shortcomings, in turn, limit equitable service delivery and undermine public faith in local government organisations. In contrast, transparent and merit-based recruitment processes have been found to improve organisational effectiveness, build workforce capabilities, and support the democratic character of public administration at the grassroots level. The paper contends that democratisation of public administration in Africa is facilitated not just by formal political reforms, but also by everyday administrative practices that govern access to public employment and services. The study expands by emphasising the need of institutionalised merit-based recruiting framework as a means of improving administrative democracy and responsive local governance. The study closes with a proposed framework.

Keywords: Community Health Worker (CHW); recruitment; selection; democratisation; governance; public administration

GLO 035

TECHNOLOGY AND ELECTORAL INTEGRITY IN NIGERIA: INTERROGATING THE NEXUS WITH GOOD GOVERNANCE

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ABSTRACT

The paper interrogates the nexus between technology, electoral integrity and good governance in Nigeria, placing emphasis on the mediating role of credible elections. Although technological innovations are generally believed to promote transparency and accountability in election administration, their ultimate importance lies in the capacity to produce credible elections that offers legitimacy to political authority and subsequently fostering good governance. The study conceptualizes electoral credibility as a critical intervening variable linking technology adoption to governance outcomes. Using a mixed-methods approach, the paper examines key technological reforms introduced by the Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC), which include Electronic Voter Registration, Bimodal Voter Accreditation System (BVAS) and electronic transmission of results to INEC Result Viewing Portal (IReV). Relying on evidence from recent general elections in the country, the study evaluates the extent to which technology have improved electoral transparency, reduced fraud and strengthened public trust in the electoral process. It further analyses how gains/deficits in electoral credibility affect governance outcomes, especially in the areas of accountability and policy responsiveness.

The findings reveal that while technology has contributed an incremental improvement to electoral integrity in the country, the impact of the gains on governance outcomes cannot be significantly established. Where electoral outcomes are perceived as credible, giving greater legitimacy to elected officials and improved prospect for accountability, persistent electoral disputes weaken the dividends of the technological reforms.

The paper concludes that technology-driven election reforms can only translate into good governance when they are effectively supported by strong institutions, political will and civic trust.

GLO 036

INVESTIGATING THE DRIVERS OF ELECTORAL CORRUPTION IN AFRICAN HYBRID REGIMES: EVIDENCE FROM THE EAST AFRICAN COMMUNITY

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ABSTRACT
The focus of this paper is to investigate triggers of electoral corruption and their implications for the democratic governance in selected hybrid regimes within the East African Community (EAC). In the wake of the wave of democratisation, most African countries have embraced electoral competition as a peaceful means of accessing power. Although there is widespread adoption of multiparty elections across hybrid regimes such as the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC), Uganda, and Kenya, concerns over electoral integrity are frequently raised by electoral stakeholders. The paper attempts to address the following question: Under what conditions is electoral corruption likely to occur in the DRC, Uganda, and Kenya? The paper proposes that in hybrid regimes, incumbent political elites are likely to engage in unethical behaviour such as electoral corruption to secure political dominance and electoral victory. It contends that electoral corruption results from the incumbent regime's ability to manipulate the electoral processes for its advantage, a practice embedded in the underlying political and socio-economic dynamics that shape the environment in which elections are conducted. Based on secondary resources, the findings of the study indicated that systemic misuse of state resources, entrenched clientelist-patronage networks, and abuse of control over state institutions serve as triggers of the manifestation of electoral corruption in the East Africa Community selected member states. The paper suggests that EAC member states should enforce principles of checks and balances, including compliance with the African Charter on Democracy, Elections, and Governance, to enhance the integrity of their electoral processes.

GLO 037

DEMOCRATIC GOVERNANCE AND CIVIC EDUCATION IN NIGERIA: PATHWAYS TO SUSTAINABLE DEMOCRACY

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ABSTRACT
Democratic governance across the world is significantly influenced by the level of civic knowledge, political awareness, and active citizen engagement. Civic education equips citizens with knowledge of their rights, responsibilities, and the workings of political institutions, thereby fostering informed participation in governance processes. Despite over two decades of uninterrupted civilian rule since 1999, Nigeria's democratic system continues to face persistent challenges, including weak institutions, electoral malpractice, low political participation, and widespread governance deficits. This paper examines the role of civic education as a strategic tool for enhancing democratic governance in Nigeria. It also identifies challenges confronting civic education and recommends ways of improving its teaching to sustain democracy in Africa. The paper is anchored on Civic Culture Theory, which highlights the role of political attitudes and orientations in sustaining democracy, as well as Social Learning Theory to explain how civic values and behaviors are acquired through formal and informal educational processes. Methodologically, the paper adopts a qualitative research design, relying on secondary data sources, including academic journals, books, policy documents, government reports, and publications from civil society organizations. Information gathered will be analysed through content analysis. The paper shows that effective civic education promotes political literacy, enabling citizens to make informed electoral choices and hold leaders responsible for their actions, instilling democratic values such as rule of law, tolerance, and civic responsibility. The paper reveals that while civic education initiatives exist within Nigeria's formal education system and through agencies such as the National Orientation Agency, their effects have been hindered by poor curriculum implementation, inadequate funding, political bias and low public engagement. The paper further finds that deficits in civic knowledge and political awareness contribute significantly to voter apathy, political manipulation, and weak accountability mechanisms. The paper concludes that sustainable democracy in Nigeria is contingent upon a strategic integration of robust civic education programs with institutional reforms. It recommends comprehensive curriculum reforms, increased investment in civic education, the use of digital media for wider outreach, and stronger collaboration between government and civil society actors. These measures are essential for cultivating an informed and active citizenry capable of sustaining democratic governance in Nigeria and Africa at large.

Keywords: Democratic Governance, Civic Education, Sustainable Democracy, Pathways, Nigeria

GLO 038

ADDRESSING INCESSANT DEFECTION AND WEAK POLITICAL OPPOSITION FOR DEMOCRATIC CONSOLIDATION IN AFRICA: INSIGHTS FROM NIGERIA

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ABSTRACT
In today, political party systems in Africa, most states, especially Nigeria is fast becoming a one-party state, because of the incessant defection that seems to have weaken the opposition parties. Expectedly, key attributes of democratic states, is strong opposition parties that constructively criticize, assess, engage the ruling government and party. Evidence has shown that strong opposition, often, keep the ruling government on its toes to provide good governance. However, the reality in Africa, especially in Nigeria indicates that incessant defection partly weakens the opposition parties, limiting their capacity to fully to check, watch, and criticize the ruling government, thus, undermining the consolidation of democracy. To address incessant defection and enhance strong opposition, capable of drawing the attention of the ruling government to the pressing needs or challenges in the country, this article, through systematic descriptive document analysis method, examines possible mitigating strategies against defection that tends to weaken political opposition in Nigeria. The findings expand knowledge on the dimension of party defections and implications for constructive political opposition and democratic consolidation in Nigeria. The findings also suggest means through which African states and Nigeria in particular, can optimize constitutionalism for the consolidation of Nigeria's democracy.

Keywords: Consolidation, defection, democracy, opposition, politics

GLO 039

NON-FORMAL POLITICAL EDUCATION: A STRATEGY FOR REVERSING POLITICAL APATHY AND IRRATIONAL VOTING BEHAVIOUR IN NIGERIA

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ABSTRACT
Non-formal political education (NFPE hereafter) is increasingly recognised as a viable strategy for addressing political apathy and irrational voting behaviour in Nigeria - both of which undermine democratic consolidation. This paper argues that NFPE is essential to building a politically informed citizenry, given that the legitimacy and sustainability of democracy depend not only on effective political representation but also on robust processes of political socialisation. Anchored in civic engagement theory and adopting a qualitative approach, the study draws on an extensive review of relevant literature to examine the potential of NFPE to deepen democratic culture and values. The findings indicate that NFPE can enhance political awareness, promote critical thinking, and foster a sense of civic responsibility among citizens, particularly the youth. Consequently, a well-structured NFPE framework can mitigate political apathy and reduce irrational voting patterns. The paper recommends the integration of NFPE into community- based civic initiatives, supported by strategic use of social media and culturally relevant communication platforms to counter misinformation and reshape political attitudes. Institutionalising NFPE within broader citizenship education programmes will strengthen informed participation and promote rational political decision-making in Nigeria.

Keywords: Non-formal political education, political apathy, irrational voting behaviour, democratic consolidation, civic engagement.

GLO 040

YOUTH AND GOVERNANCE: RETHINKING CITIZEN-GOVERNMENT RELATIONS IN AFRICA AFTER TRUMP'S RE-ELECTION

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ABSTRACT

Donald Trump's re-election as President of the United States has raised much discussion on its implications for European and Middle Eastern geopolitics. However, less focus has been placed on how the re-election would impact Africa with more than 60% of its population under age of 45, specifically with regard to governance and civic participation. African States are currently facing pressure to re-set their economic plans, political structures and development models in response to the new US foreign policy under Donald Trump which is more inward-looking with limited development assistance. This paper aims to examine how African youth view their governments in this changing geopolitical environment. It aims to fill the missing gap and answer the basic questions: How are the governments of African countries reacting to the new US foreign policy under Donald Trump? How are African citizens, largely youth, interpreting the US shift from giving aid and support as well as democratic norms? To what extent has Donald Trump's re-election influenced the relationship between African youth and their governments? Using qualitative approach, this paper draws information to analyse the political environments with young population showcasing civic involvement in governance in this particular time. It adopts content analysis to review social media discourse and mainstream media coverage since Trump's re-election to capture shifting narratives around governance and youth agency in Africa. It reveals that Trump's second term as President represents a more profound change in the balance of power and standards of governance in the world. However, for young people in Africa, this might be a time of opportunity or marginalization. This study advances a better understanding of Africa's future, on its own terms, by examining how young people are re-engaging their States. The expected contribution to knowledge is that this paper will x-ray how Africa's largest demographic group should respond as Africa faces a world in a time when traditional models of US foreign aid are fast declining. This paper will help governments in Africa to understand how to create new forms of engagement.

GLO 041

AFROCENTRIC CITIZENSHIP EDUCATION AS A RESOURCE FOR ETHICAL GOVERNANCE: A PERSPECTIVE FROM SOUTH AFRICA

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ABSTRACT

Unethical governance remains a binding constraint on Africa's economic transformation, as persistent corruption erodes human capital, misallocates public expenditure, and suppresses citizens' trust in institutions. Scientific evidence suggests compulsory, values-centred education grounded in African morals and philosophies, especially Ubuntu, can nurture future public leaders with the integrity, civic efficacy, and decision-making skills required to reverse post-colonial governance failures. This paper proposes a country-context, mixed-methods quasi-experimental design to estimate the causal impact of compulsory values-centric curricula on ethical reasoning, civic efficacy, and corruption-resistant behaviours among learners. Anchoring the inquiry in the African Union's Agenda 2063 aspirations for ethical leadership and well-educated citizens, this study will specify mechanisms that plausibly connect African moral education to improved governance outcomes over time. If validated, the findings would justify curricular reforms that integrate African ethics, civic anti-corruption modules, and experiential community service as a long-horizon, system-level strategy for strengthening governance and accelerating inclusive development.

Keywords: Afrocentrism, ethical leadership, citizen education, South Africa.

GLO 042

THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEENDEMOCRATICINSTITUTIONSAND ECONOMICGROWTH IN AFRICA

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ABSTRACT
The relationship between democratic institutions and economic growth in Africa has attracted considerable attention among scholars and policymakers due to its implications for sustainable development. This study examines how democratic institutions, including the rule of law, free and fair elections, accountability, transparency, judicial independence, and citizen participation, influence economic growth across African countries. It explores the extent to which democratic governance creates an enabling environment for investment, innovation, efficient resource allocation, and improved public service delivery. The study also considers the challenges that hinder the realisation of these benefits, such as corruption, political instability, weak institutions, insecurity, policy inconsistency, and poor governance. Drawing on existing literature and evidence from selected African countries, the study finds that while democratic institutions have the potential to promote economic growth by enhancing political stability, protecting property rights, and strengthening investor confidence, their effectiveness depends largely on the quality of governance and institutional capacity. Countries with strong democratic systems and effective public institutions tend to achieve more sustainable and inclusive economic growth than those with fragile governance structures.

The findings further suggest that democracy alone is insufficient to guarantee economic development unless it is accompanied by sound economic policies, institutional reforms, and effective leadership. The study concludes that strengthening democratic institutions is essential for achieving long-term economic growth, reducing poverty, promoting social inclusion, and improving the overall welfare of citizens in Africa. It recommends continuous efforts to improve governance, enhance transparency and accountability, strengthen the rule of law, and encourage greater citizen participation in democratic processes to support sustainable economic development across the continent.

Keywords: Democratic institutions; Economic growth; Good governance; Africa; Sustainable development.

GLO 043

REVISITING HUMAN RIGHTS AND PEOPLE LIVING WITH ALBINISM

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Abstract

People with albinism face multiple forms of discrimination worldwide. Albinism is still profoundly misunderstood both socially and medically. The physical appearance of persons with albinism is often the object of erroneous beliefs and myths influenced by superstition, which foster their marginalization and social exclusion. This leads to various forms of stigma and discrimination. People living with albinism in South Africa continue to experience various forms of social exclusion and discrimination despite the county's progressive constitutional and human rights framework. Albinism is a genetic condition characterised by a lack of melanin in the skin, hair and eyes, often accompanied by visual impairment and extreme sensitivity to sunlight. Beyond the medical challenges associated with this condition, individuals with albinism frequently face stigma, marginalization and harmful stereotypes within society. Such exclusion often results in violation of the fundamental principles of human rights. An inclusivity theory in this study is used to ascertain interdisciplinary frameworks that examine how individuals, groups, and systems integrate diverse perspectives, identities, and experiences while minimizing exclusionary practices in the society. Most of the studies conducted examined the phenotypic and genotypic characteristics of albinism and explored the challenges faced by clinicians in diagnosing albinism and issues related to genetic testing, interpretation and subsequent counselling of affected patients and their families. Ongoing research in the field of albinism is relevant to have a clearer understanding of the psycho-social effects of Albinism. Hence the importance of this study. The desktop methodology is used in this research endeavour to examine
various studies regarding the phenomenon of albinism. The study is conducted through a doctrinal and comparative research method examining the legal framework of social exclusion and human rights violation against people living with albinism.
The article argues that though legislative protection exists, persistent social attitudes and inadequate implementation of policies continue to undermine the effective protection of persons with albinism.

Keywords: Albinism, human rights, social exclusion, constitutional violation, genetic condition,

GLO 044

HOW CAN WE DISMANTLE AFROPHOBIA? REIMAGINING AFROCENTRIC CITIZENSHIP EDUCATION

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ABSTRACT

The ongoing Afrophobia in South Africa represents persistent manifestation of colonial divide-and-rule strategies that fragmented African identity and entrenched internalized self-hate among Black populations. This study conceptualizes Afrophobia not merely as episodic xenophobic violence, but as a deeply rooted socio-historical construct sustained by colonial epistemologies that continue to shape perceptions of "the African other." Within this context, the paper argues that dismantling the phenomenon requires a transformative approach centred on Afrocentric citizenship education, reconstituting African consciousness as supposed retaliatory responses. Against this premise, a comprehensive framework for delivering Afrocentric education that ensures inclusivity and widespread reach was proposed. The framework integrates six interconnected pillars: curriculum transformation, community-based and lifelong learning, media and cultural engagement, digital and open learning platforms, policy and institutional support, and continuous monitoring and adaptation. Each pillar is designed to operate across formal, informal, and technological spaces, thereby enabling Afrocentric knowledge to permeate all levels of society. Leveraging these fundamental strategies will promote critical historical awareness, ethical citizenship, and Pan-African values such as unity, solidarity, and mutual respect. In doing so, the framework addresses both the ideological and structural dimensions of Afrophobia.

Keywords: Afrocentrism, Afrophobia, citizenship education, "the African other", xenophobia.

CLOSING REMARK

Distinguished guests, keynote speakers, respected scholars, presenters, participants, ladies and gentlemen,

As we draw this remarkable conference to a close, I am reminded of another African proverb: If you want to go fast, go alone. If you want to go far, go together. Over the past hours, we have certainly travelled together, not across geographical borders alone, but across ideas, disciplines, experiences, and perspectives. When we first gathered, many of us arrived carrying laptops, conference bags, notebooks, PowerPoint slides, and perhaps a little anxiety about presentations. We leave carrying something far more valuable: new knowledge, fresh perspectives, constructive criticism and meaningful friendships.

Someone once said that conferences are unique places where people travel hundreds of kilometres to argue politely with strangers. I think that description fits us quite well. Yet those respectful disagreements have been among the greatest strengths of this gathering. Every challenging question, every thoughtful comment, and every alternative interpretation has enriched our collective understanding. Together, these conversations have reminded us that democracy is neither simple nor static. It evolves with society, and its success depends on informed citizens, responsive institutions, ethical leadership, and continuous public engagement. Perhaps the greatest lesson from this conference is that while global democratic reversal presents genuine challenges, it also invites Africa to imagine new possibilities. Rather than merely asking how democracy is declining, we have asked how democracy can become more inclusive, more accountable, more participatory, and ultimately more meaningful in the daily lives of African citizens.

But conferences are not measured by the number of papers presented or certificates distributed. Their true success lies in what happens after everyone returns home. Will today's discussions become tomorrow's research collaborations? Will these ideas influence public policy? Will the conversations begun here continue in classrooms, government offices, civil society organisations, communities, and future publications? Those are the questions that will determine the lasting value of this gathering. I therefore encourage every participant not to allow these discussions to end with the closing ceremony. Continue the conversations. Share your findings. Mentor younger scholars. Build partnerships across institutions and across borders. Africa's democratic future requires sustained collaboration rather than isolated efforts.

On behalf of the organising committee, I extend our heartfelt appreciation to our keynote speakers for challenging our thinking, our presenters for sharing outstanding research, our session chairs for guiding thoughtful discussions, our reviewers for ensuring academic quality, our volunteers for their tireless support, and every participant whose presence made this conference meaningful. To those who travelled long distances, we wish you safe journeys home. To our international guests, thank you for enriching this conference with global perspectives. To our local participants, thank you for your commitment to advancing scholarship and democratic dialogue.

May the friendships formed here endure. May the ideas shared here inspire action. May the research presented here shape better policies. And may our collective efforts contribute, even in small but meaningful ways, to a more democratic, just, peaceful, and prosperous Africa. Amen.

Thank you for your participation, thank you for your commitment, and thank you for making this conference an outstanding success. I wish you safe travels, continued success in your research and professional endeavours, and I look forward to meeting you again at our next conference.